

The Cost of Ambiguity in Instant Messaging

In a recent marketing project, a manager sent a short instant message to the design team saying, "Need the new banners ASAP." The designer thought "ASAP" meant by the end of the week based on previous workflows, so they focused on other tasks. However, the manager actually needed them by the end of the day for an emergency client review. Because the true urgency was not communicated clearly, the deadline was missed. This caused a delay in the campaign launch and strained the client relationship.

To avoid this, the manager should have used clear language instead of vague acronyms. A better message would have been, "Please provide the final banners by 4:00 PM today for an unexpected client review." Also, for important, time-sensitive requests, clearly marking the deadline in the team's shared project management software would have removed guesswork and made sure everyone knew what to expect.